Investor magnet. Savvy investors are drawn to startups armed with a comprehensive business plan. Not because they like PowerPoint decks or anything such. But because they understand the value of writing your thoughts and ideas on paper. It not only showcases your dedication, market understanding, and financial projections, but it also increases your chances of securing funding due to increased confidence.

When should you write one?

While conventional wisdom dictates a business plan should be drafted before launching your startup, it is only partly true.

What one must recognise is that a business plan is not a static document. It is a living document that evolves with your business. I won't be afraid or feel any less if I were to revisit and revise the business plan as I progress.

What should you cover and what you shouldn't?

This is not to give you conventional business plan writing tips. If you are reading this, it is likely that you already know what a business plan is and what it covers.

However, if the goal is to not just keep it as a document and convert it into an asset, then a few more details must go into it.

Adaptability strategy. With so much chaos and moving targets, a plan that describes how your business can pivot in response to unexpected market changes will go a long way. Show that you are not just planning for success but also for resilience.

Customer storytelling. Conventionally, customer stories have no place in a business plan. But that is where an asset differs from a plan. Try to incorporate narratives of how your product or service could change a customer's life. This humanises your business and adds emotional depth. It also makes you think differently.

Sustainability commitment. This is probably a new one. Earlier ESG was only on the agenda for big companies. Now it is everyone's business. In today's conscious consumer landscape, detailing your commitment to sustainability and ethical practices can be a unique selling point.

While these are a few key things to add to your business plan, I might also cover a few things that should be avoided.

Overly optimistic projections. While optimism is crucial, unrealistic financial projections can undermine your credibility. Balance ambition with grounded projections. Nearly every second startup I have seen has had out-of-the-roof projections. They don't account for inflation, unforeseen market changes, tax implications, etc.

Lengthy jargon. More often I see people trying to stuff too much jargon, just to appear and show off that they know the industry. This is vanity and I highly recommend against it. Instead, communicate your ideas clearly and succinctly. The goal is to communicate, not to show off.

Excessive detail. Do not drown in minutiae. Focus on the big picture and key strategies, leaving room for adaptability.

The point is

Crafting a business plan is more than just a ritual; it's a strategic exercise that empowers your startup to navigate the unpredictable waters of entrepreneurship.

By blending conventional wisdom with daring, unconventional ideas, you can create a business plan that not only secures funding but propels your startup toward sustainable success.

A business plan is not a static manuscript; it's a dynamic blueprint that evolves with your journey, embracing change, and harnessing innovation.

And most importantly, when you add things that are beyond convention but still relevant, a business plan can become an asset. An asset that can be used by everyone in the business. An asset that is not just stored in a file folder but frequently used for strategising and executing. EFY